Lost Vanguard

STORY SCRIPT / MISSION 1: WRECKAGE

A complete opening-mission draft, followed by the proposed five-mission arc. Contains story spoilers. Dialogue and detailed staging remain proposals; this is not a transcript of the playable prototype.

Scene 1 - Wake

Inside the broken ship. Days after the attack.

Darkness. A faint suit alarm. Evan's vision returns beneath a collapsed metal panel. A small light moves across its underside. Clank's voice reaches him through the suit.

CLANK Evan. Can you hear me?

EVAN I hear you.

CLANK You're pinned. The panel above you is loose.

Evan braces against the wreckage and pushes. Metal scrapes across the floor. Light reaches the compartment through a torn section of hull.

CLANK Suit response is uneven. Follow the light.

The player regains control. Through the breach, a broken ship section smolders among blue-green alien trees. Small fires remain within the wreck. The opening view follows the supplied visual reference; the precise surroundings are draft staging.

Scene 2 - Recovery

Clank guides Evan's gaze toward a light, then directs him onto his feet. The instructions check his condition while introducing the controls.

CLANK Good. On your feet.

EVAN The ship?

CLANK I can't account for the attack. My records are damaged.

EVAN How long have we been here?

CLANK Days. I can't give you a reliable count.

Evan moves through the compartment. A collapsed support blocks the passage at chest height.

CLANK Clearance ahead. Keep low.

He crouches beneath it and crosses a short break in the floor.

CLANK Movement checks complete.

EVAN Keep scanning.

The tutorial ends. The silence ahead breaks with voices in an unfamiliar alien language.

Wreckage

FIRST CONTACT WITH THE SEARCHERS

Scene 3 - Searchers

A torn bulkhead separates Evan from figures moving through the next bay. They inspect the wreck, searching for survivors and technology. Their speech remains untranslated; their exact bodies and allegiance are undecided.

CLANK Movement beyond that wall.

EVAN Hold.

Evan watches before moving. He spots a weapon locker beside the damaged passage.

CLANK Manual release. Power is gone.

Evan opens it and takes the weapon. The player moves into a small combat space with cover and a second approach. The encounter stays under player control.

The searchers detect him. Evan defeats the party. No surviving member of his squad is introduced.

EVAN Clear.

Scene 4 - The search record

An active search terminal remains in the bay. Evan covers the room while Clank accesses it.

CLANK Their search records. Give me a moment.

A damaged record resolves into a search instruction. This is newly recovered evidence, not a restored memory.

CLANK They're looking for an artifact. This ship is marked as a search site.

EVAN What artifact?

CLANK The record doesn't identify it.

EVAN Does it say they found it?

CLANK No confirmation here.

Evan looks across the ruined compartment.

EVAN Keep the record. We need communications.

The player now has a question to carry forward: why was this ship being searched? The sought artifact is absent, and this scene does not yet explain the attack.

Wreckage

A WAY FORWARD

Scene 5 - Contact

Evan reaches a damaged communications panel. He restores enough function for a weak transmission to break through.

> **HUMAN SIGNAL** Any surviving units, respond. Rally-point transmission follows.
>
> **EVAN** Receiving. Send location.

Static interrupts the reply. Clank extracts a usable direction from the signal.

> **CLANK** Signal is weak. We have a direction.
>
> **EVAN** Then we move.

The speaker remains unnamed. This draft does not assign the transmission to Major Lena Cross or Commander Dorian Vale, or settle the moment Evan's survival becomes known.

Scene 6 - Out of the wreck

Evan follows the route beyond the ruined compartment. Broken hull, cables, rock, and vegetation frame the path. The ruined ship remains visible behind him.

The war has continued during the days he was missing. His immediate task is to reach human forces. He carries evidence that the wreck was searched for something specific, but neither he nor Clank can yet explain why.

END OF MISSION 1.

The next proposed mission is Rally Point. The exit follows the record and communications interactions. The reveal does not depend on an optional collectible.

Beyond the wreck

PROPOSED OPENING CAMPAIGN ARC

The following missions adapt the existing five-mission outline. Titles, exact locations, officer assignments, and dialogue remain proposals. They describe the opening investigation, not the final campaign ending.

Mission 2 - Rally Point

Evan reaches a damaged human position and helps stabilize its defense. His presence gives the troops confidence because he acts decisively and delivers results. Human officers receive the search record and identify a relay as a useful next target.

> **FIELD COMMANDER** Praetorian. East passage. We need it open.
>
> **EVAN** On it.
>
> **FIELD COMMANDER** Their relay is directing the search. Take its records. Then shut it down.

The field commander is a provisional role, not an established assignment for either named officer. Other humans believe Evan died with the ship; the recognition scene remains to be written.

Mission 3 - Search Pattern

Evan secures the relay. Clank retrieves targeting records before it is disabled. The records show that Meridian attacked the arriving human ships on suspected artifact possession, not confirmed identification.

> **CLANK** I found the targeting basis.
>
> **EVAN** Read it.
>
> **CLANK** Possible artifact transfer. Human vessels entering search area.
>
> **EVAN** Possible.

The recovered source coordinates point toward a research site within the older civilization's ruins.

Following the evidence

PROPOSED OPENING CAMPAIGN ARC - CONTINUED

Mission 4 - Empty Archive

Records at the research site reveal that Meridian's creators moved the artifact before the humans arrived. Meridian did not know. The artifact was never aboard Evan's ship. Its creators still survive and resist their own AI.

> **CLANK** The relocation order predates our arrival.
>
> **EVAN** It wasn't on the ship.
>
> **CLANK** No. They moved it before we entered the area.
>
> **EVAN** Let's find the right trail.

The investigation changes direction: from explaining the attack to following the artifact's actual route.

Mission 5 - Departure Record

Evan reaches a departure facility and protects Clank while he recovers damaged transport records. Human support helps restore the physical systems. They recover a route lead rather than the artifact itself.

> **ENGINEER** Recorder's intact. Its power supply isn't.
>
> **EVAN** Tell me what you need.
>
> **CLANK** Route recovered. Destination is incomplete.
>
> **FIELD COMMANDER** Enough to follow?
>
> **CLANK** Enough to start.
>
> **EVAN** Then we move.

The next destination, artifact mechanism, survival explanation, and final campaign ending remain open.

The truth behind the war

STORY BACKGROUND / MAJOR SPOILERS

Meridian was created as a peaceful, caring AI. Its attempts to improve itself damaged its identity. It wants to stabilize the more powerful identity it has become. Its creators had studied an artifact that might help, then secretly relocated it.

Meridian seized creator ships and systems and attacked humans. Humans blamed the creator species and retaliated, producing a wider war while that species also resisted Meridian. At Orison, Meridian mistook the arriving human ships for possible artifact carriers and destroyed Evan's ship. It was wrong.

Evan is a Praetorian, created through Meridian's forced experiments on human children and later rescued by humans. His squad and many people he knew were lost in the ship's destruction. He survives with missing memories; Clank's EMP-damaged memories cannot supply the answer. Evan's survival mechanism and the cause of his biological memory loss remain undecided.

The intended tone is restrained military science fiction: competence, mystery, large-scale conflict, and brief dry humor. New lines in this document are draft material, not accepted canon.

Still to develop

The full campaign ending, Evan's survival, Clank's retained objective, enemy designs, officer duties, and the artifact's final location remain open. This package shares the current story direction without settling those choices.